

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 8

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

- ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS



- 1** Pillars and Capitals depict the Mauryan art and architecture.
- 2** The objective of construction of pillars was to carry instructions contained in the edicts of kings who commissioned it.
- 3** During the time of Ashoka, the inscription of pillars- as the symbol of the State or to commemorate the battle victories- assumed great significance.

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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PILLARS AND CAPITALS



Achaemenid pillars in the Persepolis

4

Ashoka also used pillars to propagate his ideals. Pillars of Mauryan times were **rock-cut stone pillars**.

5

They were **single piece of stone or monolithic pillars** unlike the **contemporary Achaemenid pillars**, which were constructed in pieces and then put together.

6

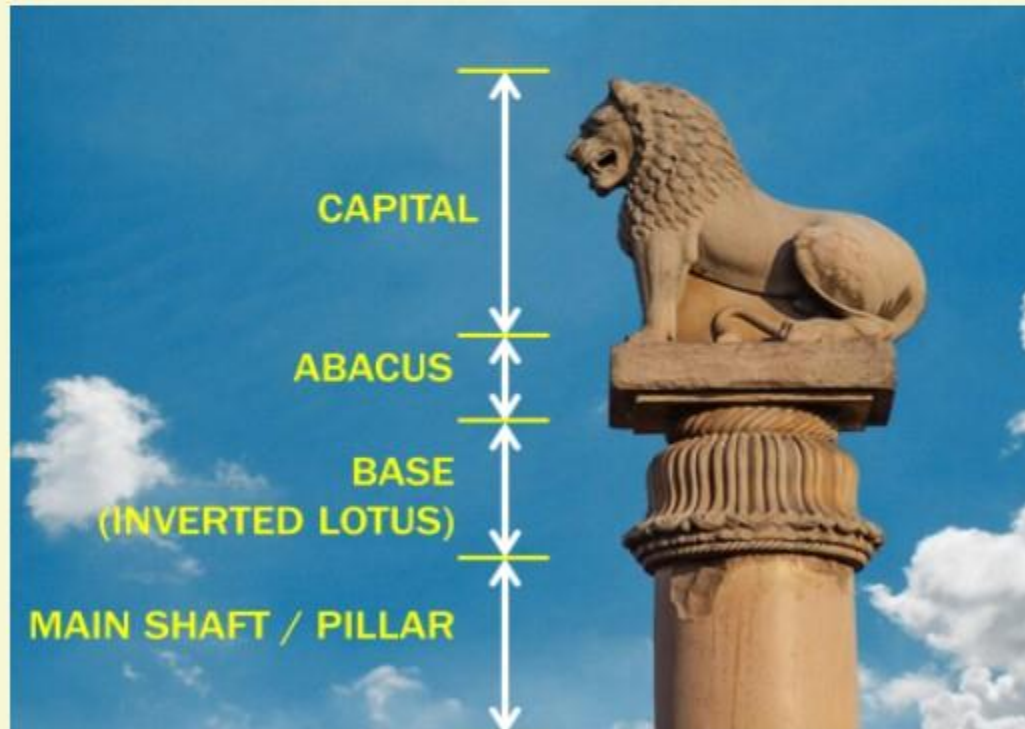
On an average the pillars were 40 feet high and they were usually made of **Chunar sand stone**.

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

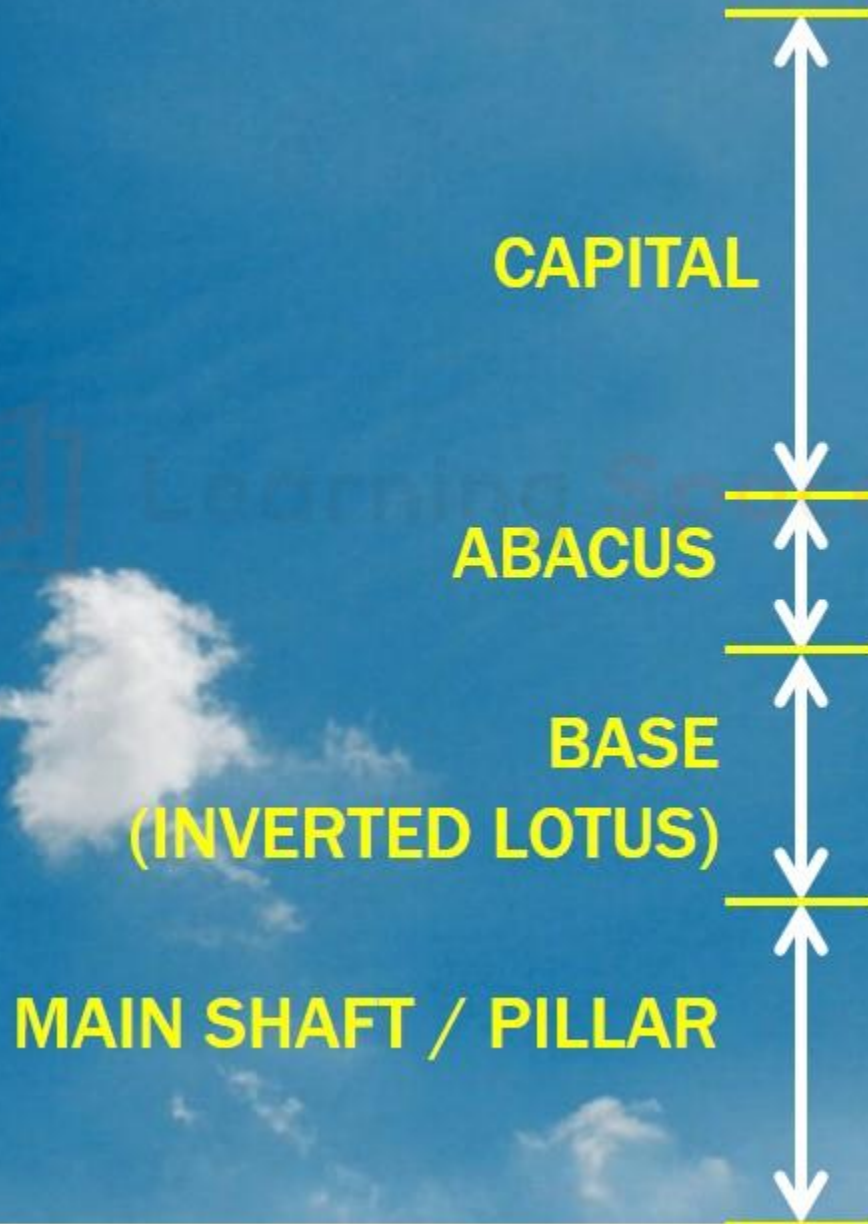
4 PILLARS AND CAPITALS

- 7** The cutting of the pillars in hard stones reflect the **skills of craftsmen** of that age.



- 8** The pillars were highly polished with inscriptions engraved on them. Atop the pillar, **capital figures** were carved animals such as those of lion, bull, elephant etc.
- 9** All the capital figures are vigorous and carved **standing on a square or circular abacus**. Abacuses are further decorated with stylised lotuses at their base.
- 10** The pillars like the Lion Capital of **Sarnath** (Uttar Pradesh), **Lauriya Nandangarh** (Bihar), **Rampoorva** (Chamapran in Bihar) are well known and belong to the Mauryan period.

PILLAR AT VAISHALI



4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS

SARNATH PILLAR



**The Ashokan Lion Capital, now
in the museum at Sarnath**

1

The pillar of Sarnath carrying the Lion Capital which forms the national symbol of the India is the most famous example of the Mauryan sculpture.

2

This sculpture consists of four parts

- a) Bell shaped base covered with inverted lotus
- b) An abacus with the figures of a horse, a bull, a lion and an elephant on it.
- c) Four chakras each having 24 spokes.
- d) Four lions placed back to back looking in the four directions

4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS

SARNATH PILLAR



The Ashokan Lion Capital, now
in the museum at Sarnath

3

All of these elements are symbolic. The lion symbolizes the Buddha with a fearless roar in all directions of truth and knowledge.

4

The carvings in the figures are especially exquisite; the muscularity of the lion is clearly visible; the polishing is very fine and mirror like.

5

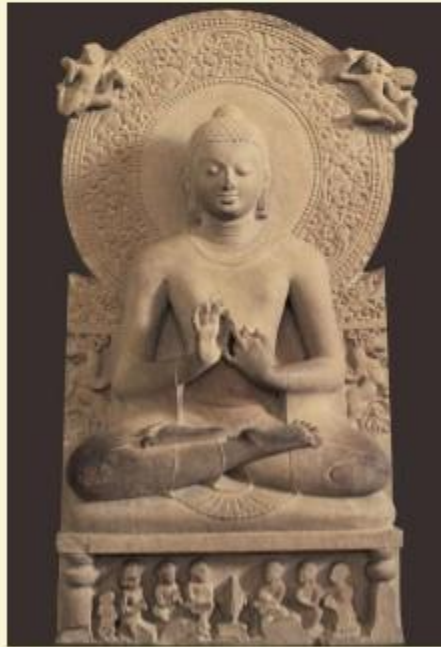
The Chakra symbolizes the turning of the Wheel of Law.

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PILLARS AND CAPITALS

SARNATH PILLAR

6 This Capital symbolizes the Buddha's historical delivery of the first sermon or the Dharmachakrapravartana.



Dharmachakrapravartana- the First Sermon of Buddha

7 The original Capital also had a Dharmachakra on the top of the four lions, this was broken and is not a part of the National symbol.



The original capital

4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS

LION CAPITAL AT SARNATH- A CLOSER LOOK



1. The Lion Capital discovered more than a hundred years ago at Sarnath, near Varanasi, is generally referred to as Sarnath Lion Capital.
2. Built in commemoration of the historical event of the first sermon or the Dhammachakrapravartana by the Buddha at Sarnath, the capital was built by Ashoka.
3. The capital originally consisted of five component parts:
 - The shaft (which is broken in many parts now)
 - A lotus bell base
 - A drum on the bell base with four animals proceeding clockwise-horse, bull, lion & elephant-and four chakras.
 - The figures of four majestic addorsed Lions
 - The crowning element, Dharmachakra, a large wheel, was also a part of this pillar.

4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS

LION CAPITAL AT SARNATH- A CLOSER LOOK



A later artistic description of the original Ashokan pillar

4. However, this wheel is lying in a broken condition and is displayed in the site museum at Sarnath.
5. The capital without the crowning wheel and the lotus base has been adopted as the National Emblem of Independent India.
6. Now kept in the archaeological museum at Sarnath, the capital has four lions firmly seated back to back on a circular abacus.
7. The lion figures of the capital are very impressive and massive.
8. The monumentality of the image is easily noticeable. The facial musculature of the lions is very strong.

LION CAPITAL AT SARNATH- A CLOSER LOOK



9. The inversed lines of the lips and its subsequent effect of projection at the end of the lips show the sculptor's observation for naturalistic depiction.
10. The lines of the mane are sharp and follow the conventions that were in practice during that time.
11. The surface of the sculpture is heavily polished which is typical of the Mauryan Period.
12. Their curly manes have protruding volume.
13. The weight of the body of each lion is firmly shown by the stretched muscles of the feet.

4 PILLARS AND CAPITALS

LION CAPITAL AT SARNATH- A CLOSER LOOK



The abacus of the Lion capital

14. The abacus has the depiction of a chakra (wheel) having twenty-four spokes in all the four directions and a bull, a horse, an elephant and a lion between every chakra is finely carved.
15. The motif of the chakra becomes significant as a representation of the Dhammachakra in the entire Buddhist art
16. Each animal figure, despite sticking to the surface, is voluminous, its posture creating movement in the circular abacus.
17. Despite having limited space between each chakra, these animal figures display considerable command over the depiction of movement in a limited space.

4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS

LION CAPITAL AT SARNATH- A CLOSER LOOK



The base with inverted lotus

18. The circular abacus is supported by an inverted lotus capital.
19. Each petal of the lotus is sculpted keeping in mind its density.
20. The lower portion has curved planes neatly carved.
21. Being a pillar image, it was conceived to be viewed from all the side, thus there are no boundations of fixed view points.
22. A lion capital has also been found at Sanchi but is in a dilapidated condition.
23. The motif of lion-capital-pillar continued even in the subsequent period.

4 PILLARS AND CAPITALS

PILLAR AT LAURIYA NANDHANGARH AND VAISHALI



Left: Vaishali Pillar
Right: Lauriya Nandangarh



- 1 This is another exquisite example of Mauryan Art. The pillar has bell shaped inverted lotus.
- 2 The abacus is decorated with flying geese and a single lion at the top.
- 3 Another famous example is the Vaishali pillar with Lion Capital.

4 PILLARS AND CAPITALS

RAMPURVA BULL CAPITAL



1 Another magnificent work of the Mauryan Period is the third century B.C. sandstone capital of the Ashokan Pillar known as the Rampurva Bull.

2 It gets the name from the site of its discovery, **Rampurva in Bihar**. At present, it is housed at the Forecourt entrance of the Rashtrapathi Bhavan.

4 PILLARS AND CAPITALS

RAMPURVA BULL CAPITAL



Persian motifs in the capital structure

3 The Rampurva Bull is noted for its delicately sculpted model demonstrating superior representation of soft flesh, sensitive nostrils, alert ears and strong legs.

4 It is a mixture of Indian and Persian elements. Whereas the motifs on the base, atop the inverted lotus, the rosette, palmette and the acanthus ornaments are not Indian features, the bull capital is a masterpiece of Indian craftsmanship.

4 PILLARS AND CAPITALS

RAMPURVA BULL CAPITAL



5 Weighing up to five tonnes, this invaluable artifact became a part of Rashtrapati Bhavan in the year 1948 after it came back from Burlington House, London where it had gone to take part in a grand exhibition of Indian art.

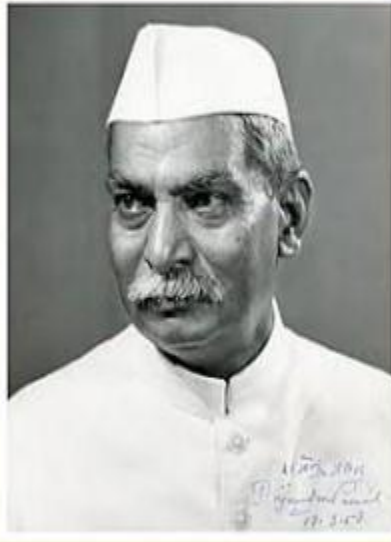
6 On its return, along with other artifacts, the Rampurva Bull was kept for display at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

7 The Rampurva Bull sculpture is said to have a velvet touch.

4

PILLARS AND CAPITALS

RAMPURVA BULL CAPITAL



8

This was at the initiative of Dr. Rajendra Prasad and Pandit Nehru who took keen interest in this priceless piece of history and decided that it would remain at the Rashtrapati Bhavan instead of being shifted to the newly constructed National Museum building which had come up at Janpath in the year 1960.

INTERESTING TITBITS ABOUT THIS BULL CAPITAL

1. While deciding for a perfect location to display the Bull, many suggestions were made. It was the wish of Indian President and Prime Minister that The Rampurva Bull be placed at a “conspicuous location” at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.
2. The two preferred locations were the Durbar Hall entrance or the Forecourt under a specially erected canopy to protect the Bull from damage from the elements.
3. It was also suggested that the Bull may be shifted to the Central Asian Antiquities Museum.

INTERESTING TITBITS ABOUT THIS BULL CAPITAL

4. Pandit Nehru wrote against it in a letter dated January 13, 1952, stating, “I should like the Bull to be prominently displayed for the people to see. I do not like the idea of its being immersed in the darkness of the Asian Antiquities Museum.” He also added that he did not want damage to be done to this piece of history and art as, “It is too valuable and precious.”
5. After many rounds of discussion, it was finally settled that The Rampurva Bull should be displayed at the front portion of the veranda, immediately between the two central pillars.

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE



- 1 Viharas
- 2 Chaityas
- 3 Stupas
- 4 Pillars and Capitals
- 5 Sculptures
- 6 Rock-cut Caves
- 7 Palaces
- 8 Pottery



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